
A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

BUILDING THE FORMATION AGAINST A CLASSICAL CENTER

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-01 The full formation as a study position

The formation is a starting point for decisions.

HB-02 White chooses Be2

Quiet opponents can win by restricting every break.

HB-03 White develops Be3 and Qd2

Identify the opponent's king choice before fixing yours.

HB-04 White fianchettoes the king bishop

Opening a diagonal can activate both bishops.

HB-05 White keeps the c-pawn on c2

Watch the next central expansion, not only the current one.

HB-06 An early queen exchange option

Once the center opens, leave the formation mindset.

Pocket reference / 2

LARGE CENTERS AND EARLY PAWN ATTACKS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-07 The three-pawn center

More opposing space demands earlier central action.

HB-08 The four-pawn center

Against four pawns, finish development and challenge them.

HB-09 The Austrian-style f4 center

Counterplay must arrive before the center breaks open.

HB-10 An immediate h-pawn attack

Stopping one lever creates a new contact to monitor.

HB-11 White plays g4 early

Counter a wing attack through the center when it is safe.

HB-12 White advances e5 early

Respond to a central break immediately.

Pocket reference / 3

OTHER FIRST MOVES AND POSITIONAL SYSTEMS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-13 Against the London bishop

The bishop on f4 changes the e5 square.

HB-14 Against the Colle structure

A prepared e4 changes the pace of the game.

HB-15 Against the English Opening

Flexible opposing pawns require flexible development.

HB-16 Against the Reti

Expect the opponent to change structures.

HB-17 Against the Bird

Identify which central square the f-pawn supports.

HB-18 Against 1.b3

Check the long diagonal before completing a fianchetto.

Pocket reference / 4

PAWN-BREAK CHOICES AND PARTIAL FORMATIONS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

HB-19 Prepare ...c5 with development

Prepare the break and calculate its consequences.

HB-20 Use ...d5 to challenge e4

A central break is a concrete transformation, not a slogan.

HB-21 White closes with d5

A closed bishop needs a future pawn break.

HB-22 Meet the e5 advance by exchanging

Compare blocking with exchanging before fixing the center.

HB-23 A queenside space grab with a4

If a break is restrained, choose another useful plan.

HB-24 White tries Bh6

Check the knight's square before a queen recapture.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

HIPPO CONTEXT

The publisher's public description of The Hippopotamus Defence identifies a double-fianchetto system and partial formations. This course is independently authored; it does not reproduce that commercial book or its games.

<https://www.newinchess.com/the-hippopotamus-defence>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.